

DIKE A sheet of intrusive igneous rock inclined vertically or at a steep angle to the surface. A large number of dikes in an area are referred to as a dike swarm. Also known as a dyke. See also *basalt*, *igneous intrusion* (panel), *sill*.

DISTRIBUTARY A branch of a river that flows away from the main watercourse and does not reconnect with it later, for example in a delta.

DIVERGENT BOUNDARY The line along which two or more tectonic plates are moving away from each other, for example at a mid-ocean ridge. See also *boundary* (panel), *mid-ocean ridge* (panel).

DOLINE See *sinkhole*.

DOME VOLCANO A mound-shaped, steep-sided volcano. The shape is determined by the viscous nature of the lava, which cannot flow far from the vent. See also *volcano* (panel).

DRAINAGE BASIN The area within which all surface water from rain, melting snow, or ice is drained by a single river system. See also *catchment area*, *watershed*.

DROWNED COAST A stretch of coastline that has been inundated by a rise in sea level. Features of such coasts include drowned valleys (or rias). See also *isostasy*, *ria*.

DRUMLIN A streamlined mound of sediments left behind by a glacier after it has retreated. See also *glacier*, *moraine* (panel).

DRY FOREST Woodland growing in an area with a primarily dry climate.

DUNE See panel, below.

DYNAMIC METAMORPHISM The transformation of rocks brought about mainly by directed pressure or stress, rather than heat or chemical change.

E

ECOREGION A large area containing a distinctive group of species, communities of species, and environmental conditions.

ECOSYSTEM A community of interacting life forms and their environment. An ecosystem could be as small as a rotting log or as large as Earth.

EDDY A circular motion of any size and speed, in water or air. See also *vortex*.

EKMAN SPIRAL The tendency of deep ocean currents to change direction as they approach the surface, and of winds to change direction as they get closer to the ground. See also *Coriolis effect*.

EL NIÑO The phenomenon in which warm water from the western Pacific flows eastward, making the eastern Pacific warmer than usual and triggering worldwide changes to weather patterns. See also *La Niña*.

EMERGENT Describing forest trees that grow taller than the height of the canopy. See also *canopy*.

EMERGENT COAST A stretch of coastline along which formerly submerged features (for example, beaches and wave-cut platforms) have been exposed by a fall in sea level.

ENDEMIC A term for animals and plants native to one region and found nowhere else.

ENDORHEIC Describes a watershed or a lake that has no outflow to a larger body of water.

EPHEMERAL Temporary, as in a water body present only in the wet season.

EPIPHYTE A nonparasitic plant that grows on another plant.

ERG A large expanse of vegetation-free sand in a desert.

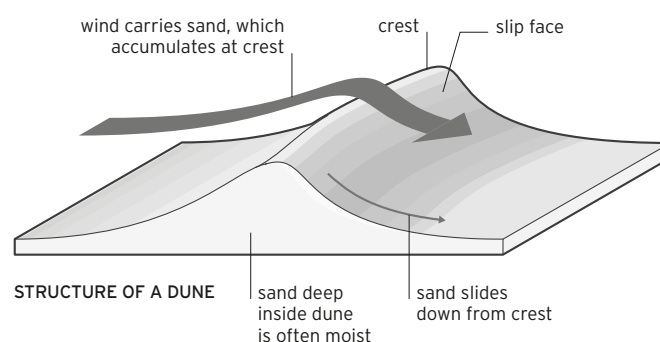
EROSION The processes by which water, moving ice, and wind, as well as the sand grains and other particles they carry, scrape and wear away rocks or soil from a land surface. See also *weathering*.

EROSIONAL COAST A coastline where there is net removal of sand, gravel, and other sediments.

ERRATIC A rock that has been transported, usually by a glacier, from its original location. See also *glacier*.

DUNE

A dune is a mound of sand in a desert, on a river bed, or close to the shore of a sea or lake, formed by the action of the wind or the flow of water currents. Dunes occur in a range of shapes and sizes, depending on how they have formed. With desert dunes, if the prevailing wind is usually from one direction, crescentic barchan or parabolic dunes will form. If the wind is variable, linear or star dunes will result. Dunes may migrate many kilometres or become stabilized by vegetation.



DUNE TYPES

